

During Reconstruction, the flourishing Black churches became community centers. Black ministers prophesied a new age of freedom, comparing emancipated slaves to the Israelites released from bondage. Churches hosted local events, offered help writing letters and reading newspapers, and nurtured political participation.

Education mattered greatly to freedmen. Most states had banned the education of enslaved people, and literacy rates were low. With help from the Federal government and Northern missionaries, Black communities established schools that attracted people of all ages. In time, Reconstruction schools multiplied along with the number of Black teachers.



Marriage of a Black soldier

A Black couple is married by Chaplain Warren of the Freedmen's Bureau. On being freed, many Black couples married, knowing they could not be lawfully separated.